WAR FOR DUMMIES

OPERATIONS TONGA & DEADSTICK

- Hey, Grampa, here's your pipe!
- Oh! So, you still want a story!
- Oh yes, Grampa, the English and the horse with wings!
- You mean Pegasus Bridge, eh? Huh. If someone had told me that one day I'd have to speak well of those limey rosbifs...

THE WHY AND THE HOW

As part of the invasion of the continent this 6th of June, 1944, the British have a heavy responsibility to insure that the left flank of the Allied attack aligns with the greater vision of seizing the important city of Caen. The first operation is dubbed Tonga. On the eastern flank, the Orne and a canal that connects Caen to the sea. Both waterways are notably crossed by two bridges: one over the Caen Canal at Bénouville (Euston I, renamed later to Pegasus Bridge in honor of the insignia of the 6th Airborne), and the other over the Orne at Ranville (Euston II, renamed later to Horsa Bridge in honor of the gliders). Their capture is critical for blocking the avenues that facilitate a German counterattack, and so this operation is named Deadstick (or Operation Coup de Main — so British). The 6th Airborne of Major General Gale, to whom the mission has been entrusted, must also neutralize the battery of Merville, supposedly equipped with 150mm cannons, capable of shelling the beaches (notably Sword Beach). Finally, they must blow up five other smaller bridges east of the Orne, always with the goal of making things difficult for the Germans.

HAM & JAM

In the weeks preceding the assault, the men of Company D of the 2nd Ox & Bucks of the 6th Airlanding Brigade trained hard under orders by Major Howard. As with the rest of the preparations for Operation Overlord, the Allies went all-out. So, replicas of the bridges were constructed in England for the hundreds of volunteers to train, day and night, in conditions as close as possible to the real deal.

When the time came on June 5, 1944, six Horsa gliders flew overhead, drawn by Halifax bombers. Crossing the channel is business as usual, and the gliders are released around Cabourg to glide to their objectives. Three gliders head toward the Bénouville bridge (Euston I, Landing Zone X), and succeed in the incredible feat of landing in the dead of night, in unknown enemy territory, with nearly no sophisticated instruments beyond a compass and a few wristwatches, within 50 meters of the bridge. It brings a tear to my eye!

Both bridges are guarded by units detached from the 716th ID of the Wehrmacht, a static division installed for quite some time in the sector; their heavy equipment was mostly captured from the enemy (French and Czech cannons), and integrated into the casemates of the coast. This unit is largely composed of Ostruppen or older soldiers, without much experience and with limited combat capability. In addition, numerous soldiers from this division were offered a lovely holiday on the Eastern front, which was hungry for cannon fodder, and the 716th ID, sprinkled over the sector, is at no better than 50 % of its theoretical effectiveness.

The fact remains that at 00:25, the Germans are thoroughly surprised. There is nothing but the sound of the rough landings of Major Howard's gliders, which is mistaken for the crashing of a bomber that would have gone down after the diversionary bombing organized later by the English.

Recovering from their emotions (a glider assault into the middle of nowhere does not tend to keep one's nerves cool), the British soldiers progressed toward the bridge and silently "neutralize" the first sentries (in military jargon, "neutralize" is a euphemism that means "bleed like a pig").

A little further on, the guards, intrigued by the noise, come out of their billets to find themselves face-to-face with the commandos, who open fire immediately. The alarm has been triggered.

The Germans react quickly... and badly. It's one of those panicked, disorganized situations that the experts commonly characterize as a SNAFU. Flares firing off, STEN bursts, smoke grenades, phosphorous grenades; it takes 10 minutes for the the English to become masters of the Bénouville bridge, which they were surprised to discover was not rigged with explosives.

At Ranville (Euston II, Landing Zone Y), the results are a little less self-evident. One glider landed about 150m from the bridge; another, approximately 1.5km; and the third, 10–12km out. So with fewer than 30 men, Lieutenant Fox of platoon 17 seized the bridge over the Orne, facing Germans that were certainly alerted by the sound of combat from Bénouville, but overwhelmed quickly nonetheless.

Results of the operation: two killed and fourteen wounded British. Both bridges are under Allied control, and Major Howard sends a carrier pigeon with the codewords Ham & Jam (I know, right?) to inform the Allies that both bridges were taken intact.

Now they just needed to wait for their relief.

Amusing historical note: The first French house liberated by the Allies would be La Chaumine café near the bridge, a pub. Vive la France!

Blue Bonnets Over the Border

The tune that Lord Lovat asked Bill Millin, his personal bagpiper, to play in *The Longest Day* is called "Blue Bonnets Over the Border". What the film does not say is that this tune is alluding to the white cockade on the blue bonnet that identified the Jacobite Scots, who (violently) supported the Catholic Stuart family's claims to the throne of England against the Orangemen / Hanoverian Protestants from the late 17th Century through the 18th Century. Basically, a family tale.

March, march, Ettrick and Teviotdale,
Why the deil dinna ye march forward in order?
March, march, Eskdale and Liddesdale,
All the Blue Bonnets are bound for the Border.
Many a banner spread
Flutters above your head,
Many a crest that is famous in story.
Mount and make ready then,
Sons of the mountain glen,
Fight for the Queen and the old Scottish glory.
Come from the hills where your hirsels are grazing,
Come from the glen of the buck and the roe;
Come to the crag where the beacon is blazing,
Come with the buckler, the lance, and the bow.
Trumpets are sounding,
War-steeds are bounding,
Stand to your arms then, and march in good order;
England shall many a day
Tell of the bloody fray,
When the Blue Bonnets came over the Border.

THE NIGHT WILL BE LONG

The English think that it won't take long for the Germans to react, and Howard reinforces the Bénouville bridge with a group of men entrenched in Ranville who, from their side, will gather the other English soldiers scattered during the landings.

On the German side... nothing. Or pretty much. There are quite a few German units around, but they had been warned that there would be exercises firing blanks that night on the theme of pushing back an enemy commando (is fate just teasing them, or what?). As it turns out, just a pair of light tanks come to take a peek, and one of them is quickly taken out of the running.

Over the course of the night, the Germans grope without much determination. But as dawn approaches, the pressure increases. The English positions become the targets of mortar fire, and the wounded begin to accumulate. By mid-morning, three German river vessels from Ouistreham appear before the bridge. Two were destroyed, but the third managed to turn back. A little later, a german bomber managed to drop a bomb directly onto the bridge... and the bomb bounced into the canal without exploding.

It's 12:32, two minutes behind schedule, and the bagpipes sound that the English and a few French from the 1st Special Service Brigade of Lord Lovat are joining up with Howard's men.

Operation Deadstick is a complete success, with an improbable helping of good luck.

War, Cricket and Marmelade

While the Americans give their operations and procedures powerful, pounding names like Overlord, Cobra, or Flash & Thunder, the English prefer more picturesque names like Tonga, Goodwood, Epsom, or Ham & Jam (What an awful combination! Are these people monsters?!). Just what is this supposed to tell us about the difference in attitude of the two armies?

Well, I guess that the English are simply crazy by nature. No offense!

NEW RULES

NIGHT COMBAT

In the scenarios set at night, the maximum range, the penalty for shooting at long range, the dispersions, and the range for revealing concealed units are modified according to the conditions of the night (Dark Night or Clear Night).

Dark Night

The maximum range for shots is **7** spaces. Beyond this distance, it is impossible to fire.
The penalty for long range starts at **5** spaces.
The maximum range of **7** spaces also applies to the Limited Range special ability if it is greater than **7** spaces.

In order to discover a unit hidden in a terrain overlay, you must be adjacent to it.
A unit can hide in open terrain (outside of a terrain overlay) if no enemy is within **2** spaces with a clear **LoS** on the hidden unit.

Dispersion from indirect fire is augmented by **2** spaces.

No direct fire with the Indirect Fire special ability.

The range of indirect fire is not affected.

It is impossible to play **Aviation** cards.



Clear Night

The maximum range for shots is **9** spaces. Beyond this distance, it is impossible to fire.
The penalty for long range starts at **7** spaces.
The maximum range of **9** spaces also applies to the Limited Range special ability if it is greater than **9**

In order to discover a unit hidden in a terrain overlay, you must be adjacent to it.
A unit can hide in open terrain (outside of a terrain overlay) if no enemy is within **4** spaces with a clear **LoS** on the hidden unit.

Dispersion from indirect fire is augmented by **1** space.

The range of indirect fire is not affected.

It is impossible to play **Aviation** cards.



The Sun Rises...
In certain scenarios, the darkness of the night can change, and the sun can rise. Special markers permit you to indicate these changes on the turn counter.

Flames and Light Sources
Light Sources and Flames illuminate all adjacent spaces.
Whenever you shoot at units in one of these illuminated spaces, apply the firing rules from the rulebook in the base game.
This even applies to discovering hidden units that are situated in the illuminated spaces.

SLEEPING UNITS

Certain units start the scenario sleeping.
These are indicated by the Sleeping marker.

Deploy them on the gameboard by placing the Sleeping marker on them.
Deploy them with their "inactive" side showing, if they have one.
They can neither receive Order tokens nor Activated markers, nor can they be moved during the Supply Phase.
Sleeping units cannot benefit from the effects of an Action card.

A sleeping unit cannot be targeted by a shot unless the enemy unit is within **2** spaces of the sleeping unit.
If the sleeping unit is in a building, it cannot be targeted by a shot unless the enemy unit is adjacent to the sleeping unit. In any case, a sleeping unit is obviously still affected by blast patterns.

A sleeping unit that is attacked as part of an Assault is automatically eliminated.

When shot, sleeping units suffer damage normally.

A unit sleeping outside (not in a building) wakes up as soon as a shot or explosion rings anywhere on the terrain.

A unit sleeping in a building wakes up whenever:
- A shot is taken either from a space inside the same building, or from a space adjacent to the building.
- The Destruction ability is used in or a blast pattern overlaps either the same building, or a space within **5** spaces of the building.
- An Assault takes place in the same building.

A unit with an Order can wake a sleeping unit if they are adjacent at the end of its movement.

Once awake, the unit loses its Sleeping marker, but immediately receives a Suppressed marker. It loses the Suppressed marker at the end of the Supply Phase of the current turn, or if an Action card or a special ability removes it.

GREAT DEFENSIVE POSITION



If the blast pattern is centered on the central interspace of the great defensive position, the units inside the defensive position do not benefit from the defensive bonus the defensive position usually confers.
An enemy unit that moves from one space of the defensive position to another space of that same defensive position can be the target of opportunity fire from another unit in that same defensive position.
Remember: A unit with a Suppressed marker no longer exerts **ZoC**.

BUNKER

These terrain overlays function like other buildings, except that they cannot be destroyed, and no unit can enter through the windows except by using a card or special ability.

The units, Equipment, or blast patterns with the Demolition special ability can try to knock out the units inside the bunkers by firing either directly at them or the bunker itself. Roll a number of dice corresponding to the value indicated in the symbol. If you roll at least a **6**, place one (and only one) Suppressed marker on each unit in the bunker. Hidden units are not affected.



VICKERS MACHINE GUN